

BANDEEP SINGH

CITIZENSPEAK

‘Less govt, more privatisation’

SATYA NARAYAN AGARWAL, *77*
Chairman, Bhoruka Group

When he moved to Bangalore from Calcutta 50 years ago, the city welcomed him warmly, recalls Satya Narayan Agarwal. He was then running the Transport Corporation of India, one of India’s largest logistics firms, headquartered in West Bengal. But with the Naxal movement, several industrialists like him found Bangalore a safer haven. Despite his wealth, Agarwal prefers to stay in a narrow lane off Benson Cross Road, in a refurbished house he bought decades ago. He finds the city’s failing infrastructure appalling. He recalls how it used to take him just 15 minutes to reach Whitefield industrial estate, where he had set up shop. Today, it takes him an hour. He jokes, “There is a road somewhere amidst the potholes, not the other way round.” He believes that a metropolitan city like Bengaluru should plan for development for the next 50 years, as cities like New York and Paris did. Privatisation of civic amenities, he thinks, is the way forward, particularly in power distribution and water supply, as it will lead to more accountability and curb corruption.



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‘We should avoid band-aid solutions’

IRFAN RAZACK, *69*
CMD, Prestige Group

Razack recalls Bangalore as a sleepy little town in the ’60s. Today, he is possibly the largest builder in the city, who has been instrumental in its growth into a giant megapolis. Starting as a real estate broker, Razack saw his company’s growth skyrocket in the 1990s after the IT sector boom. He has put up over 250 highrise office complexes across the city, including the snazzy UB City for Vijay Mallya. He dismisses claims that it was the politician-builder nexus that led to Bengaluru’s civic woes. “I can tell you that the building laws in the city are clear-cut. It would be a crime to stop development. But at the same time, we shouldn’t do it mindlessly. Whatever we do now to improve the infrastructure shouldn’t be band-aid solutions.”

Razack believes that the private sector should be roped in to improve accountability. He is not in favour of pouring resources into a ‘twin city’ that many experts are proposing. “It’s like I need a heart surgery and instead the doctor decides to do it on someone else in the hope that it will cure me,” he says.

per km for a metro whereas it would have cost Rs 5 crore a km to make a dedicated lane for buses. We must get our priorities right. The word economy and ecology come from the same Greek root word ‘eco’—meaning home—and people forget they must be said in the same breath.”

2. An Unholy Nexus

The second major reason for the decline of the city is the arbitrary way in which the affairs of the Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP), or the Greater Bengaluru Municipal Corporation, have been handled. The BBMP was set up in 2007 by the then H.D. Kumaraswamy government by merging the hundred wards of the erstwhile Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike, seven city municipal councils, one town municipal council and 110 villages surrounding the city into a single administrative area. Almost overnight, Bengaluru’s municipal jurisdiction grew from 200 sq. km to 800 sq. km and the total number of wards increased from 100 to 198. With no accompanying planning to expand its administrative capabilities and inadequate funds to meet the demands placed by this fourfold expansion in territory, a senior state official in service then recalls, “Bengaluru became ungovernable with all of us firefighting for amenities rather than planning ahead. It led to ad hoc development, increased corruption and sent the city down the tube.”

The only one to benefit was the politician-businessman-